COMP 3700A: Contributing to Open Source

Exploring FOSS communities (continued)

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Housekeeping

- Do we have notetakers for today's topics?
  - Goal is to have the PR for each topic submitted within **1 week**
  - After submission, I will add a reviewer — you may request specific topic
  - If you are chosen as reviewer, you may decline the invitation
- Lab 3: I invited everyone with an open PR to have "maintainer" priveleges

Today's Goals

- A few more comments on licensing
- Pick up where we were interrupted with the fire alarm!
  - Common documents ✓
  - Project activity
  - Communication channels
- Understand the various roles in FOSS communities
- Non-code contributions (if we have time...)

> *I will use Inkscape and QBittorrent as examples. Please pick 1-2 others to look at and answer questions during this class.*

Licence considerations

- When you contribute to a project, you typically agree to the license
- There may even be a contributor license agreement
- Every source has bias! For example, Codeberg vs GitHub
- Mixing licenses can be tricky

> *In general, you should be aware of the license for your project, but most of the time you probably won't be affected by it*

LibreOffice is also a famous example of a project forking over (among other things) copyright disagreements

Evaluating project activity

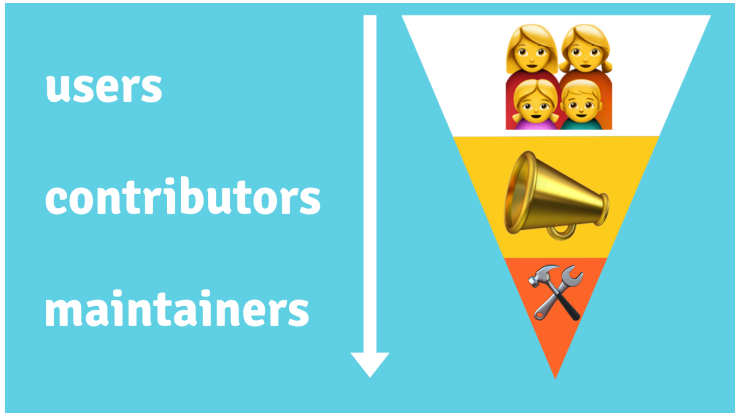
- Issues (GitHub) or Work Items (GitLab) are "to do" items
- Pull/merge requests are accomplishing the "to dos"
- Consider:
  - Which items get closed and why
  - Which get lots of comments
  - Age of open items
  - Tags
- What are the official communication channels, and how often do people post?



How active are the projects? What communication channels are most used?

Roles in FOSS projects

- You are already a **user** — might submit bug report
- This semester, you will become a **contributor**:
  - Reproduce bugs
  - Write code, documentation, translations
  - Someone will review your submission
- **Maintainers** are the project leaders who review and merge PRs, manage releases, etc
- The bus factor in FOSS is often very low!



Source: https://mikemcquaid.com/the-open-source-contributor-funnel-why-people-dont-contribute-to-your-open-source-project/



What are the key roles? Who are the people in these roles?

Non-code contributions

- At a certain scale, FOSS projects need all kinds of expertise
- Documentation in its various forms
- UI/UX designers
- Translators
- Bug reporters and triagers

> *Homework: Find and post an example of a non-code contribution*